Emergence of British Rule in India & War of Independence

Mughal India: The Starting Point

- Strong centralized empire under
  - Akbar, Jahangir and Shah Jahan
- Cultural, architectural, & administrative zenith
- Religious tolerance under policies like ***Sulh-i-Kul***
- Decline began post-Aurangzeb (1707)
  - Weak successors, regional revolts, rising Maratha and Sikh powers
- Vacuum exploited by European powers

Early British Presence

- **East India Company:** formed for trade **(1600)**
    - The Company was granted charter by Queen Elizabeth I
    - Aim: Trade with the East (spices, textiles, raw materials)
    - Established trading centers (factories):
        - Surat 1612
        - Madras 1639
        - Bombay 1661
        - Calcutta 1690
- Initially no political ambitions
- Post-Mughal decline
    - Shift from commerce to conquest
- **Anglo-French rivalry** (Carnatic Wars)
    - Gave British upper hand

Key Turning Points

- **Battle of Plassey (1757):**
  - Fought between Siraj-ud-Daulah and Robert Clive
  - Betrayal by Mir Jafar
- **Battle of Buxar (1764):**
- British vs combined forces of:
    - Mughal Emperor Shah Alam II
    - Nawab of Awadh
    - Mir Qasim
- Decisive British victory
- Treaty of Allahabad (1765)
- Company gained **Diwani Rights of Bengal**
- **Tipu Sultan's resistance** (Anglo-Mysore Wars):
  - Symbol of Muslim resistance

Expansion through Strategies

- **Doctrine of Lapse (Dalhousie):**
  - Annexation of states without male heirs
- Major states annexed:
  - Jhansi
  - Satara
  - Nagpur
- **Subsidiary Alliance:**
  - Indian rulers forced to maintain British troops
- **Divide and Rule Begins:**
  - Preference to loyal local groups

War of Independence 1857: A Defining Moment & its aftermath

- Lasted from May 1857 to July 1858
- Joint Hindu-Muslim action against British rule
- British labelled it “Sepoy Mutiny”
- Indians Called it ‘War of Independence’
- **Delhi destroyed**, **Bahadur Shah Zafar exiled:** Mughal rule ended
- Shook the foundations of the East India Company’s control
- After 1857
  - Muslims faced severe backlash that led to **economic, educational, & political isolation** of Muslims

Causes of the War

- **“Every revolution has its spark—but it is born from long-standing fires.”**
  Let’s categorize:
- **A. Long-term Causes:**
- **Political:**
  - Annexation of princely states (e.g., Doctrine of Lapse)
  - Humiliation of local rulers
- **Economic:**
  - Land revenue policies impoverished peasants
  - Destruction of local crafts and industries

Causes Continues...

- **Social & Cultural:**
  - Perceived threat to religion and traditions
  - Christian missionary activities and social reforms seen as intrusive
- **Military:**
  - Discrimination in ranks, salary, promotion of Indian sepoys

- **B. Immediate Cause:**
- Introduction of **Enfield Rifle cartridges** allegedly greased with cow and/or pig fat
  - Offended both **Hindus** and **Muslims**
  - Sparked open rebellion among sepoys in **Meerut** on May 10, 1857

The Spread

- Rapid spread to major cities:
  - **Delhi, Kanpur, Lucknow, Jhansi, Bareilly**
- **Bahadur Shah Zafar** declared symbolic emperor
  - **Rani Lakshmibai, Nana Sahib, Tantia Tope** led fierce resistance
- Fierce retaliation by British troops with support of:
  - Loyal princely states
  - Divide and rule policies in action:Punjab, Sindh, and some princely states sided with the British

Reasons of Failure

- Lack of Central Leadership
- Poor Organization & Communication
- Limited Geographic Spread (mostly North India)
- Superior British Weapons & Strategy
- Divide and Rule worked effectively

British Response & Brutality

- Retaliation and mass executions: villages burned, entire populations punished
- Delhi devastated:
  - Bahadur Shah Zafar exiled to Rangoon
- Doctrine of Lapse repealed

Political Effects of British Rule

- End of East India Company **&** Governance transferred to **British Crown (1858)**
  - British Parliament passed Government of India Act 1858
- **Queen Victoria's Proclamation (1858):**
  - Promised religious freedom, non-interference
  - British policies became even more repressive
- End of sovereignty of Indian states
- Centralized administrative system introduced and Indians excluded from real power
  - Army reorganized to prevent future mutinies:
    - Increased ratio of British soldiers
    - Preference to 'loyal' communities (e.g., Sikhs, Gurkhas)

Political Effects of British Rule: Rise of Nationalism

- Western political ideas introduced that led to spread of political consciousness
- Formation of:
  - Indian National Congress (1885)
  - Represented Indian voices
  - Later became Hindu-majority
- All-India Muslim League (1906)
  - **Protected Muslim interests**, rights
  - Initially cooperative with British & Congress
- Political awakening:Demand for rights and self-rule increased over years
  - A new India was emerging that had sense of rights and identity based upon western political slogans
  - Emergence of educated middle class. Movements like Aligarh, Deoband, and Brahmo Samaj emerged as socio-cultural and religious responses

Economic Effects – Deindustrialization & Drain of Wealth

- Destruction of cottage and handicraft industries
- Indian artisans lost livelihood
- British manufactured goods flooded Indian markets
- India became a consumer economy
- Heavy taxation and revenue extraction
- Wealth transferred to Britain
- India reduced to a raw material supplier
- Frequent famines due to mismanagement

Land Revenue Systems

- Permanent Settlement (Zamindari)
- Ryotwari System: direct tax collection
- Mahalwari System: indirect/through village heads
- Exploited peasants and increased poverty

Social Impacts

- **Policies of ‘divide and rule’ were intensified**
- Muslims blamed disproportionately for the revolt
  - Retribution against Muslim elites, institutions, and landowners
- **Encouraged communal differences**
  - Introduced communal electorates (later in 20th century)
  - Preferred Hindus in civil jobs
  - Census used to reinforce ethnic differences
  - Islamic education and Urdu language suffered heavy setback
- **Introduction of Western education**
  - English replaced Persian
- New legal systems, railways, and telegraphs were introduced

Administrative and Legal Effects

- Modern bureaucracy introduced
- Police and judicial system established
- Codified laws implemented
- System served British interests primarily

Muslim Responses: Resistance & Reform

- **Focus on education and religious revival**
- Aligarh Movement (Sir Syed Ahmad Khan)
- Muslim scholars: **Shibli Nomani**, **Nawab Mohsin-ul-Mulk**
- Modern Muslim education
- Urdu literature thrived as a Muslim expression
- Muslim participation in local councils and press gradually increased
- Deoband Movement
- Two nation Theory :Laid foundation for Muslim political awareness

Conclusion

- British rule initiated due to waning Indian political structure and eventually strengthened by British strategies
- Effects were largely exploitative and damaging
- Modern state system/institutions introduced gradually
- Rise of freedom movement/struggle
- Communal political identity strengthened; ultimately, paved way for nationalism and independence
- Two-Nation Theory gained momentum: Led to Partition of India (1947)

